

# The teenage badminton prodigy juggling schoolbooks and smash shots

At 16, Tanvi Sharma is already a BWF World Tour finalist, **Junior World No. 1**, and a Class 11 student. Here's how she's balancing studies, travel, and global badminton ambitions.

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**T**anvi Sharma didn't get to celebrate when she reached the final of the US Open World Tour 300 – her debut on the BWF World Tour – in Council Bluffs, Iowa, last month. She had travelled alone, and after a quick call to her mother and coach in India, she returned to her hotel room, cooked some rice, and paired it with the ready-made food she had brought from home.

Then she opened her Class 11 Economics and English textbooks and began to study. "I usually make it a point to study for at least two hours a day," says the 16-year-old.

That she has to manage school along with a burgeoning badminton career makes Tanvi's achievement even more remarkable. Only three other Indian women's singles players – Saina Nehwal, P.V. Sindhu, and Malvika Bansod – have ever reached the final of a BWF World Tour 300 event. Tanvi even came close to winning the title. She took a game off former World No. 9 Beiwen Zhang before eventually losing 11–21, 21–16, 10–21.

Even in defeat, the performance turned heads. With Saina retired and Sindhu nearing the twilight of her career, many see Tanvi as a standout prospect for the next generation of Indian women's singles players.

Tanvi's coach, Park Tae-sang, compared her attacking game favourably to Sindhu, whom he had guided to Olympic bronze in Tokyo. Veteran commentator Gillian Clark has observed similarities between Tanvi's game and that of Saina.

Tanvi hopes she embodies elements of both. "My coach, Park sir, told me my attacking game was like Sindhu, and I think the rest of my movement is like that of Saina *didi*. But I know I have a long way to go to match what they've achieved," says Tanvi, who keeps a picture of Tai Tzu Ying as her phone wallpaper — a quiet nod to the creative flair she also hopes to bring to her game. She is currently training at the National Badminton Academy in Guwahati for the Asian Junior Championships scheduled later in July. As the current Junior World No. 1, she's expected to perform well there.

Tanvi's mother Meena never imagined her daughter would be seen as a successor to two Olympic medallists. "I have two daughters